

Ellie's Chess Power-Up Plan

What your games are teaching you,
and how to become even stronger

873 → 990

your rapid rating in 8 weeks

15

wins since July

10

winning positions to turn into wins

Made on 24 September 2026 from your 31 Lichess games (30 July – 22 September), checked move by move by a chess engine. Go through it with your coach.

Look How Far You've Come

You have gone up about **120 rating points in eight weeks**. You scored **15 wins, 5 draws and 11 losses**, and here is what you already do well:

What you do well	Proof
You start games well. You develop your knights, castle and fight for the center.	Your opening moves are your most accurate moves.
You get winning positions all the time.	You were winning in 10 of the games you didn't win!
You can play really clean games.	18 Sep (London) and 9 Sep (Four Knights): zero big mistakes.
You spot mates.	20 Sep: after 14...Bxd1 you played 15.Bxf7# !
Your basic mates are strong.	King + queen vs king: 5 out of 5 in your drills.

The big secret in your games

You are already good enough to get winning positions. The next step is **finishing them**. If you had won just half of those 10 games, your rating would be a lot higher already, and you wouldn't need to learn anything new. You just need a few new habits.

Your 4 Power-Ups

These are the four things that cost you the most points. Each one can be fixed with practice.

Power-Up 1: Finish the job

When you're winning, the game isn't over yet. You gave away wins with stalemate, pawn races and queen tricks.

From your games: on 30 Aug you had **two queens and a rook** and played 48.Qg6?? which was stalemate. 48.Qd8 was checkmate!

Your new habit: when you're winning, **trade pieces, keep your king safe, and check for stalemate on every move** once your opponent only has a king left.

Power-Up 2: Guard your king

Sometimes your queen goes on a pawn hunt far away while your opponent attacks your king.

From your games: on 30 Aug your queen took pawns on a2, c2 and d3, and then 21...Qa5?? allowed Qxg7#. You still had 8 minutes on your clock.

Your new habit: **one pawn is not worth my king.** Before your queen grabs a pawn, look at which enemy pieces can reach your king.

Power-Up 3: Checks, captures, threats

Your opponents make lots of mistakes, and sometimes you miss them. Sometimes you also miss your own winning checks.

From your games: on 21 Sep, **25...Qxa1+** would have taken a free rook with check.

Your new habit: before every move, say **CCT**: my Checks, Captures and Threats, and then my opponent's.

Power-Up 4: Slow down at stop signs

Most of your big mistakes were played in **under 10 seconds**. In the games you lost, you still had about **5½ minutes** left on your clock.

From your games: you move in about 5 seconds, even in dangerous positions.

Your new habit: think **20 seconds or more** at every stop sign (next page). You have plenty of time!

Stop Signs

At a stop sign, take your hands off the pieces and think for **at least 20 seconds**. In a 10-minute game you can do that about 10 times and still have lots of time left.

STOP SIGN	Ask yourself
My opponent just captured or gave check .	Can I take back? Is there something better?
An enemy piece moved toward my king .	What is it threatening? Do I need to defend?
I want to take a pawn with my queen .	Is my king safe if my queen goes away?
I think I'm winning .	How could I lose from here? Can I trade pieces?
There are only a few pieces left .	Is this stalemate? Whose pawn queens first?

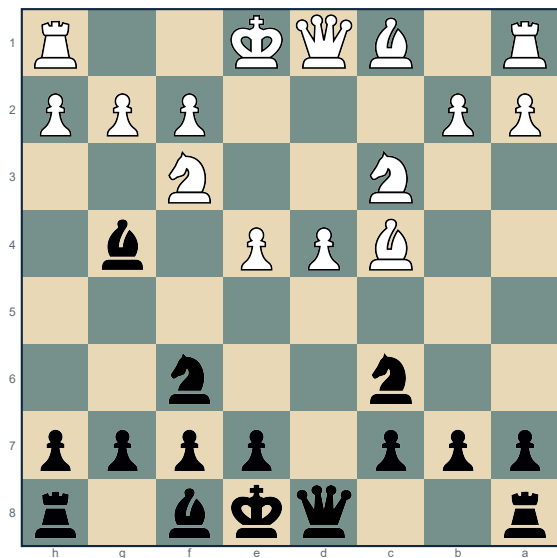
My Tournament Card: keep this next to your scoresheet

- 1. Every move: CCT.** Checks, Captures, Threats. Mine first, then my opponent's.
- 2. Stop signs mean 20+ seconds.** Capture or check · piece coming at my king · queen grabbing a pawn · I'm winning · few pieces left.
- 3. When I'm winning:** trade pieces · keep my king safe · stop their passed pawn · check for stalemate.
- 4. Use my clock.** Losing with lots of time left is the worst way to lose.

Puzzles From Your Own Games

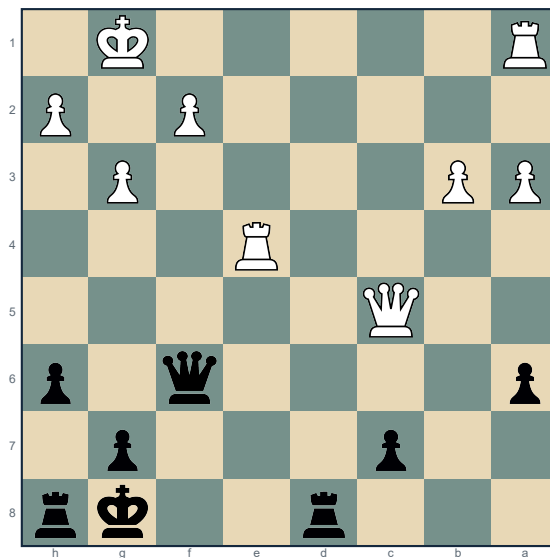
Every position below happened in one of your games. The boards are shown from your side. Try each one before you look at the answers!

Puzzle 1 · Take away the defender



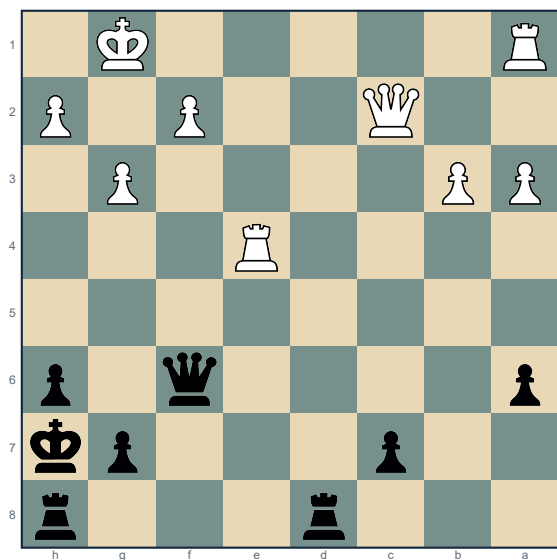
Black to move. Is 6...Nxd4 safe? What is the best way to win the d4 pawn?
Hint: Look at 7.Qxd4 Bxf3. Can White play a check first?

Puzzle 2 · Free piece with check



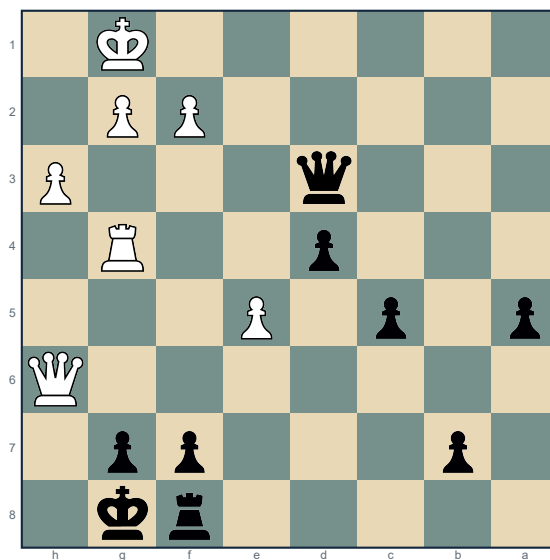
Black to move. Win material.
Hint: Look along the long diagonal from your queen.

Puzzle 3 · Hidden check



Black to move. What is White threatening?
Hint: What is the white queen on c2 looking at?

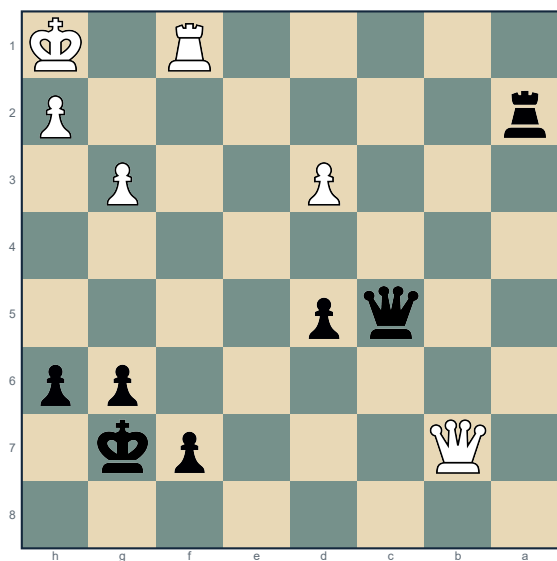
Puzzle 4 · A check that wins



Black to move. Win material.
Hint: Checks first! Which check also hits something?

Puzzles From Your Own Games (continued)

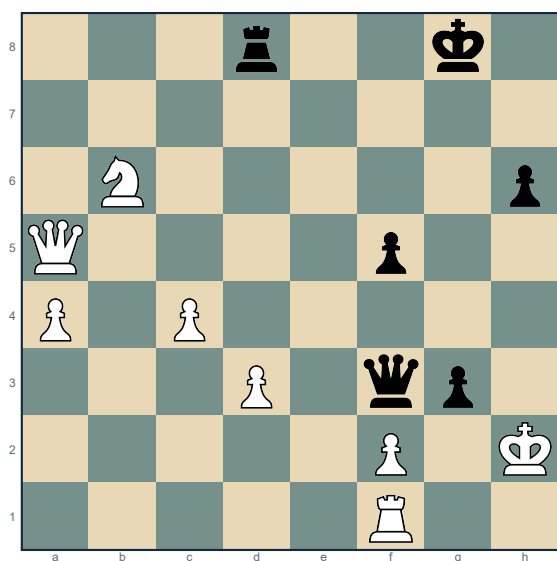
Puzzle 5 · Guard your king



Black to move. What does White want to do to f7? Stop it!

Hint: Count the attackers on f7.

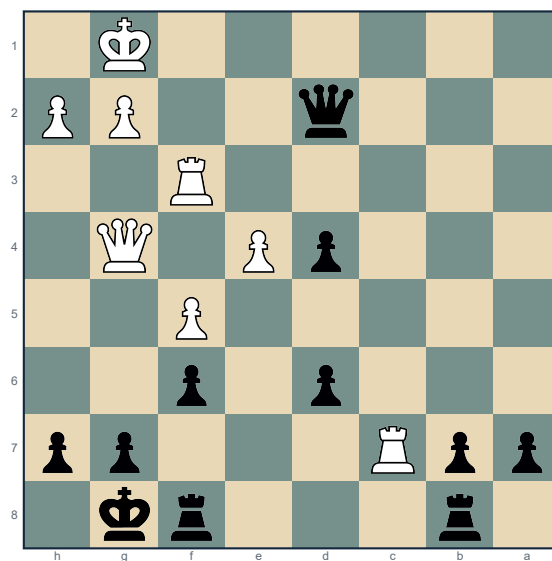
Puzzle 7 · Where does the king go?



White to move. Why is 40.Kh3 a disaster? Where should the king go?

Hint: What does ...g2+ do?

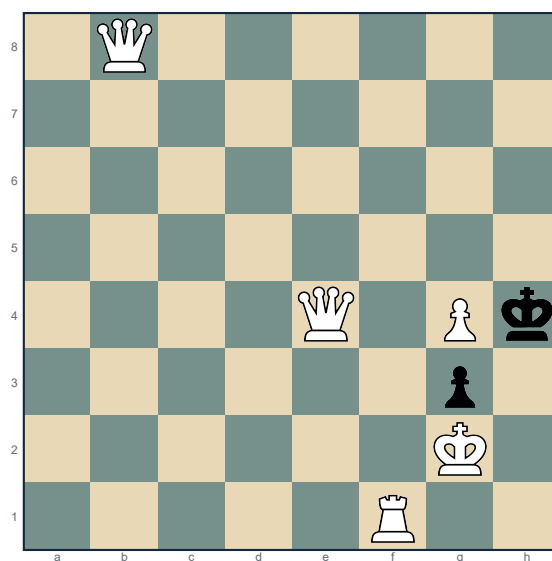
Puzzle 6 · Guard your king



Black to move. Find White's threat first. Then find your move.

Hint: Look at g7.

Puzzle 8 · Watch out: stalemate!

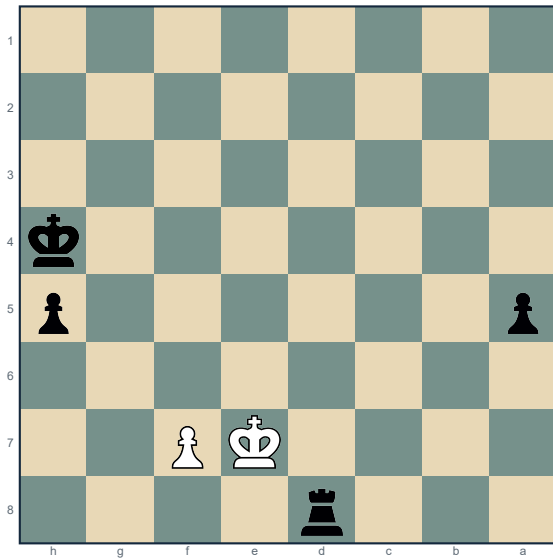


White to move. Mate in one! Which natural move is stalemate?

Hint: The black king has almost no squares.

Puzzles From Your Own Games (continued)

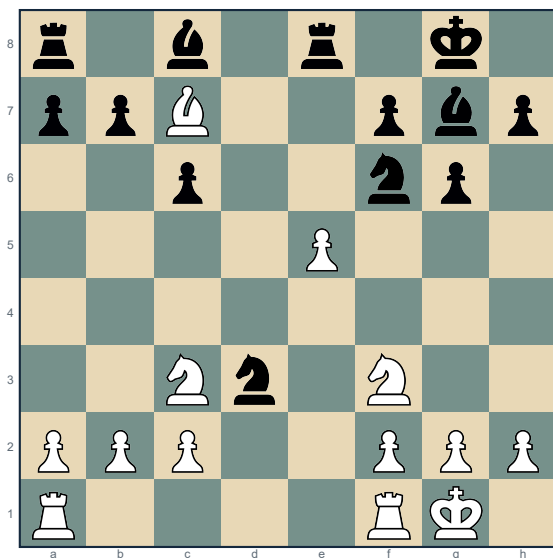
Puzzle 9 · Pawn race



Black to move. Push your a-pawn, or stop White's f-pawn?

Hint: Who gets a queen first?

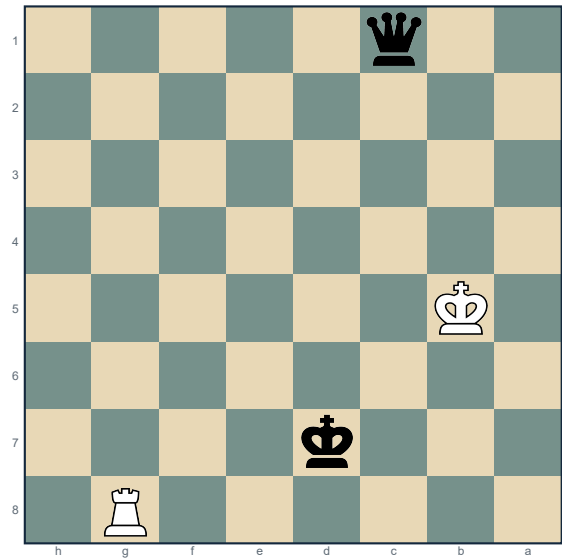
Puzzle 11 · In-between move



White to move. Don't take on d3 yet! What's better?

Hint: Captures: which one also attacks something?

Puzzle 10 · Queen vs rook: skewer!

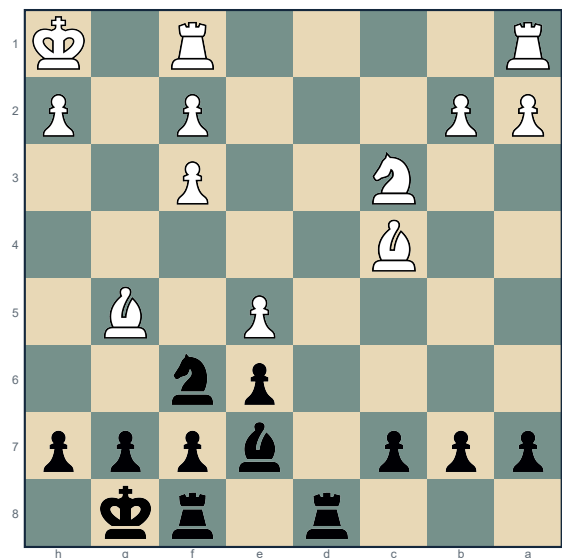


Black to move. Why does 73...Qc7 lose the queen?

Find a safe move.

Hint: Can the rook check your king AND hit the queen?

Puzzle 12 · Is the knight stuck?



Black to move. Your knight on f6 is attacked. Is it really pinned?

Hint: What is behind the knight? Is it protected?

Answers

Only look after you have really tried!

#	Answer
1	6...Bxf3! 7.gxf3 Qxd4 wins the pawn safely. After 6...Nxd4? 7.Qxd4! Bxf3, White plays 8.Qxd8+ (check first!) and Black loses a piece. <i>Take away the defender, then take the pawn.</i>
2	25...Qxa1+ takes a free rook, and it is check! In the game you played 25...Kh7.
3	If the rook on e4 moves, the queen on c2 gives a discovered check on h7. 26...Qg6! blocks the line. In the game 26...Rhe8?? lost to 27.Rxe8+.
4	27...Qd1+! 28.Kh2 Qxg4. The check wins the rook on g4.
5	White wants Qxf7+ , then Qf8+ and Rf7+. 33...Rf2! blocks the f-file and you are still winning. In the game 33...Qc3?? got mated.
6	White threatens Qxg7# . 21...Qd1+ or 21...Rf7 stops it. In the game 21...Qa5?? 22.Qxg7#.
7	After 40.Kh3?? g2+ the pawn attacks the rook and becomes a queen. 40.Kg1 (or 40.fxc3) holds.
8	48.Qd8# is mate (so is 48.Qh7+ Kg5 49.Qh5#). In the game 48.Qg6?? was stalemate: Black had no legal move and was not in check, so it was a draw.
9	47...Rb8! (then ...Rf8 and ...Rxf7) stops the f-pawn and Black wins. In the game 47...a4?? 48.Kxd8 let White queen first.
10	73...Qc7?? 74.Rg7+ is a skewer : check, then Rxc7. Win with safe checks like 73...Qb2+ 74.Ka6 Qa2+ 75.Kb6 Qe6+ 76.Kc5 Qxg8.
11	14.exf6! takes the knight first. After 14...Bxf6 15.cxd3 you are a piece up.
12	13...Nd5! The knight is only pinned to a <i>protected</i> bishop. After 14.Bxe7 Nxe7 nothing is lost.

My Practice Plan

Every day (25–30 minutes)

Time	What to do
10 min	Lichess puzzles by theme. Change the theme each day: Hanging piece · Mate in 1 · Mate in 2 · Discovered attack · Intermezzo · Defensive move · Queen endgame
10 min	Before solving a puzzle, say out loud: what is my opponent threatening?
5–10 min	Replay one of your own games and find the move you missed.

With my coach, one week at a time

	Week 1: CCT. Puzzles 1–4 with your coach. Say "CCT" before every move in 2 practice games.
	Week 2: Guard your king. Puzzles 5–7. Replay your 6 Aug and 30 Aug games with your coach.
	Week 3: Finish the job I. Puzzles 8–9. Win a winning position against the computer without stalemate.
	Week 4: Finish the job II. Queen vs knight drill (your trickiest one!) and Puzzle 10.
	Week 5: Tricky moves. Puzzles 11–12. Intermezzo and discovered attack puzzles.
	Week 6: Check-up. Look at your last 10 games with your coach. Were the mistakes at stop signs?

For the next 4 weeks, play practice games at **15+10** instead of 10+0 so you can practise stopping at stop signs.

My goals

My goal	Now	In 6 weeks
Big mistakes per game	about 3	under 2
Winning positions I don't win	10 in 31 games	almost none!
Queen vs knight drill	2 out of 6	5 out of 6
Clock left when I lose	5½ minutes	I used my time

My Mistake Notebook

After every loss or draw, write one line. When the same line keeps coming back, that's what to practise next with your coach.

Game / date	I lost (or drew) because I missed...

Remember: every strong player lost games exactly like these. You are already getting winning positions. Now let's finish them. You've got this, Ellie!